from power. The catalyst was Saeed's appointment of Hafiz Abdul Rehman Makki, his cousin and brother-in-law, to head the Department of External Affairs.[5] Iqbal believed that as the senior member of the group he deserved this post. A split was ultimately averted through internal negotiations and Makki assumed the position.[6]

The Department of External Affairs liaised with jihadi organizations inside and outside Pakistan. US and European officials believe that, through this department, Lashkar established close ties with more than a dozen jihadi groups in the Middle East, Southeast Asia and parts of the former Soviet Union.[7] Its operations wing also managed many of Lashkar's transnational operatives, overseeing activities ranging from reconnaissance for terrorist attacks to the provision of support or equipment for the group's military operations. In addition to liaising with jihadi outfits and operatives, this department also promoted the organization's agenda to foreign governments and political parties. Between 9/11 and March 2002 it sent off in excess of 3,000 letters and emails to 130 countries.[8]

Technically the group's headquarters is located at Jamiat al-Qadsia in Lahore, which is where its leadership has their offices. But the nerve center was built on a sprawling compound in Muridke. Its proper name is the Markaz-e-Taiba [Taiba Center]—meant to evoke the holy city of Medina, for which Taiba is an appellation—but it is commonly referred to simply as Muridke. Located about an hour's drive from Lahore, just off the Grand Trunk Road, Muridke is intended to be a beacon of the pure Islamic life. Sharia is enforced, all shops close during the call for prayer and music, television and smoking are forbidden.[9] Saeed has claimed affluent traders put up the money to buy the land on which it is built, and that two Saudis each contributed 10 million rupees for the early construction done there.[10] Mahmoud Mohammad Ahmed Bahaziq (one of MDI's founders) and Abdul Rahman al-Surayhi (Lakhvi's brother-in-law), two Saudis present at MDI's inception, provided a sizeable amount of the money for Muridke according to Noman Benotman who spent time working with Lashkar during the early 1990s and knew both men.[11] Open source evidence supports this assertion. A Pakistani lawyer alleged in the Lahore High Court in 2003 that interlocutors for Bahaziq approached his firm in the 1990s about constructing an educational complex at Murdike.[12] In their work on Islamist networks in Afghanistan and Pakistan, Mariam Abou Zahab and